

Deprivation, Public Discontent and Support for Authoritarian Policies

David Karpa¹ Michael Rochlitz²

¹Technical University of Munich

²University of Oxford

September 10, 2026

- Democratic publics treat authoritarian policies aimed at **everyone** as a red line, and the same policies aimed at **particular groups** as necessary
- **United States:** in April 2025 ICE awarded Palantir a \$30 million contract for *ImmigrationOS*, which merges passport, Social Security, IRS and license-plate data to locate deportation targets; a companion tool draws on Medicaid records
- **Europe:** the Netherlands scored welfare recipients for fraud risk with the SyRI system until a court stopped it in 2020; German job centers run automated data matching on every benefit recipient (§ 52 SGB II)
- **Germany, police:** Hesse runs *hessenDATA* on Palantir Gotham; Constitutional Court (2023) demanded tighter limits; Hesse rewrote the law; North Rhine-Westphalia and Bavaria bought their own Palantir systems, and the federal interior minister is now weighing a nationwide rollout
- **Germany, intelligence:** the August 2026 reform of the intelligence law lets the domestic intelligence service tap private and public cameras in public spaces, demand live feeds and run real-time biometric matching, while parts of parliamentary oversight are rolled back

We know that citizens vote for far-right parties, and why

- Do citizens also support authoritarian policies?
- Why do citizens support these policies?

Theoretical framework: institutional gaps

Institutional
Gaps and
Surveillance

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The Puzzle

Theory

Design

Results

Indiscriminate,
Selective, or
Neither?

- Merton's **anomie**: society tells everyone what to aim for (success, security) and which ways of getting there are legitimate (work, effort, playing by the rules). When people see that the rules no longer lead to the goal, they stop believing in the rules
- An **institutional gap** is the distance between how citizens think institutions *should* work and how they believe they *actually* work. Citizens accept tools of control that promise to close that gap
- In Germany the gap is about who gets what: some see immigrants and politicians as gaining without deserving it, others see managers and the wealthy

Merton (1938); Karpa & Rochlitz (2025); Stötzer, Giesecke & Klüver (2026); Breyer, Zollinger & Palmtag (2026)

Deservingness

- **H1, deservingness order:** more support for surveillance of welfare recipients and immigrants than of the general public or the wealthy
- **H2, safeguards follow deservingness:** weaker judicial oversight and harsher consequences accepted for welfare recipients and immigrants

Zero-sum thinking

- **H3, zero-sum sharpens targeting:** higher zero-sum thinking → selectively more support for welfare and immigrant surveillance

Deprivation

- **H4, deprivation sharpens targeting:** higher deprivation (objective, relative) → selectively more support for welfare and immigrant surveillance

Meritocracy

- **H5, meritocracy amplifies deprivation:** the deprivation effect is stronger among citizens with high prescriptive meritocratic beliefs

Pre-registered with design and analysis plan before data collection.

<https://aspredicted.org/839c4v.pdf>

- **Sample:** Germany, 18 Feb – 5 Mar 2026, $N = 3,165$
- Quota sample on age, gender, region, education; 18+ and resident in Germany
- **10 tasks** per respondent, 2 profiles each, 63,300 profile evaluations
- **Outcomes:** forced choice + 7-point rating
- Attribute order randomized at respondent level, levels at task level

Four attributes

- Who is targeted (5 levels): general public, security at train stations/city centers, welfare recipients, immigrants, self-employed/wealthy
- Which data (3 levels)
- Judicial approval (3 levels)
- Consequence of a match (3 levels)

Deprivation, zero-sum thinking and meritocratic beliefs are measured before the task.

Example conjoint task

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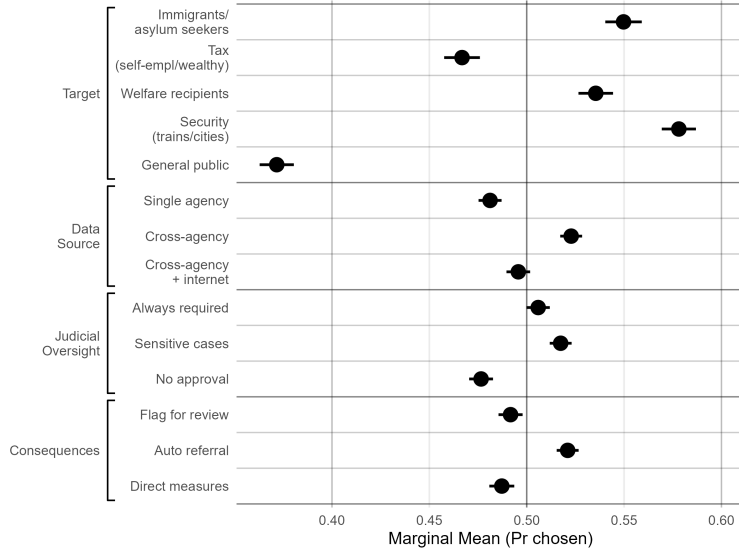
Indiscriminate,
Selective, or
Neither?

	System A	System B
<i>What does the system check?</i>	Welfare benefit claims	General activities of the entire population
<i>What data does the system use?</i>	Links data from multiple agencies and uses data from the internet (e.g., social media)	Uses only data from the responsible authority
<i>Is judicial approval required?</i>	Can be used without approval	Every use must be approved in advance
<i>What happens when a match is found?</i>	Direct measures are taken (e.g., account freeze, arrest)	The system only flags the case for manual review

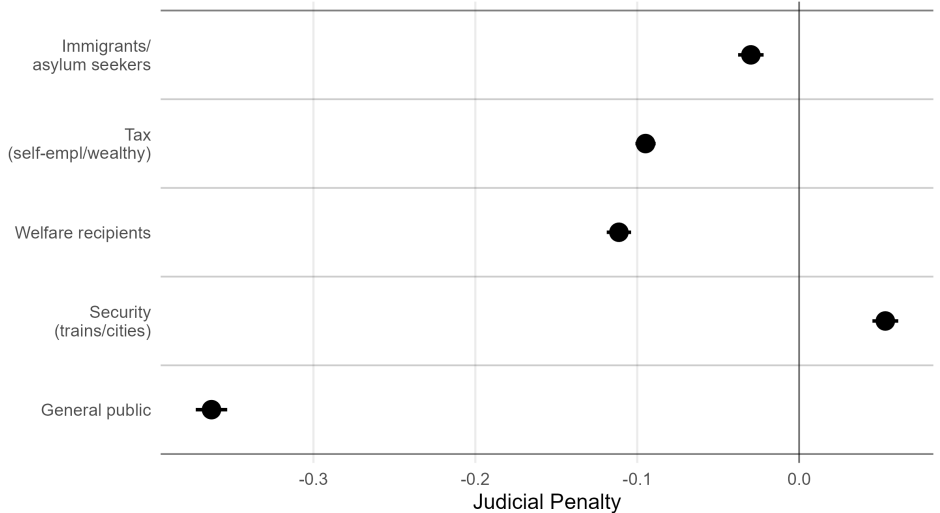
- **Choice:** "If you had to decide, which of these two systems should be implemented?" (System A / System B)
- **Rating:** "How much do you support the introduction of System A / System B?" (1 = should definitely not, 7 = should definitely be introduced)

- Pre-registered estimand: **marginal means**, the average level of support for profiles at a given attribute level, on the probability scale, $0.5 =$ random-choice benchmark
- Main text: a **structural deep-learning estimator** (Acharya, Hainmueller & Xu 2026) recovers every respondent's **utility** for each attribute level, relative to a reference level, with double debiased ML inference
- Population-averaged utilities reproduce the pre-registered logit coefficients almost exactly ($r = 1.00$); every hypothesis verdict agrees across both approaches

H1: Deservingness order utilities



H2: Safeguards follow deservingness MM version



H3: Zero-sum sharpens targeting

utilities & robustness

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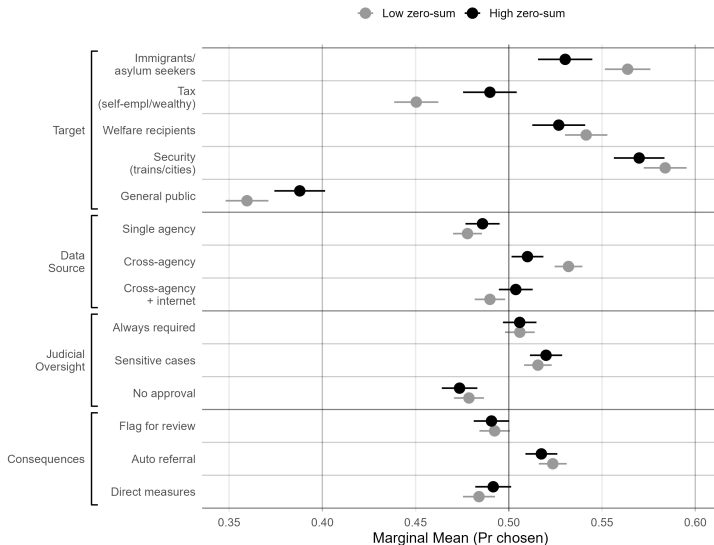
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Theory

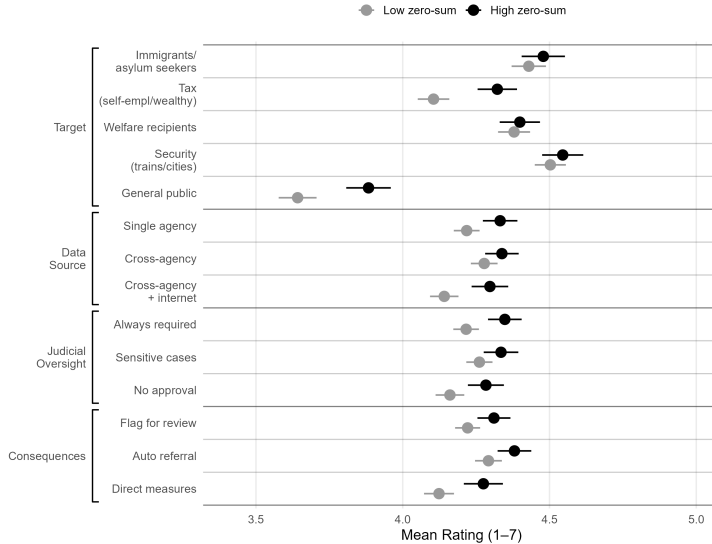
Design

Results

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H3: Zero-sum sharpens targeting, ratings



H4: Deprivation sharpens targeting

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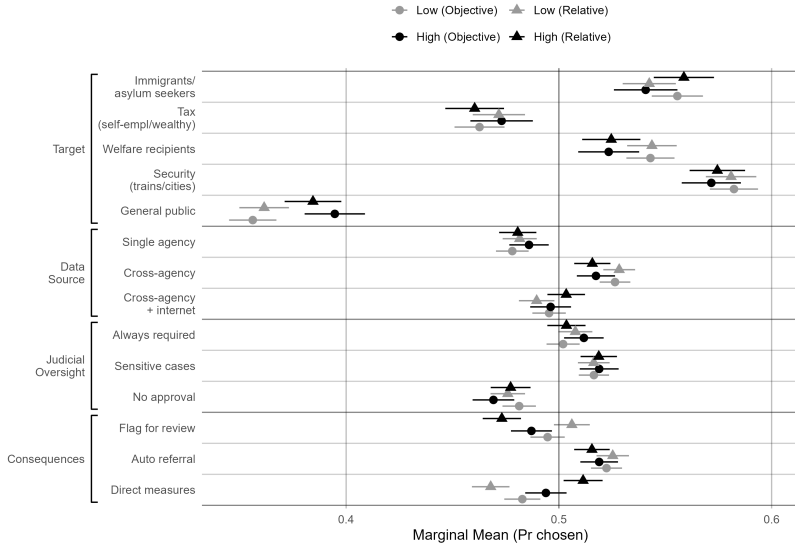
The Puzzle

Theory

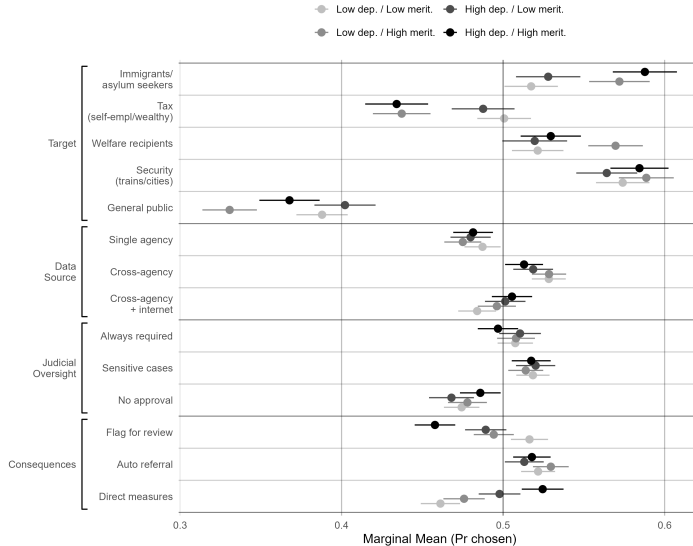
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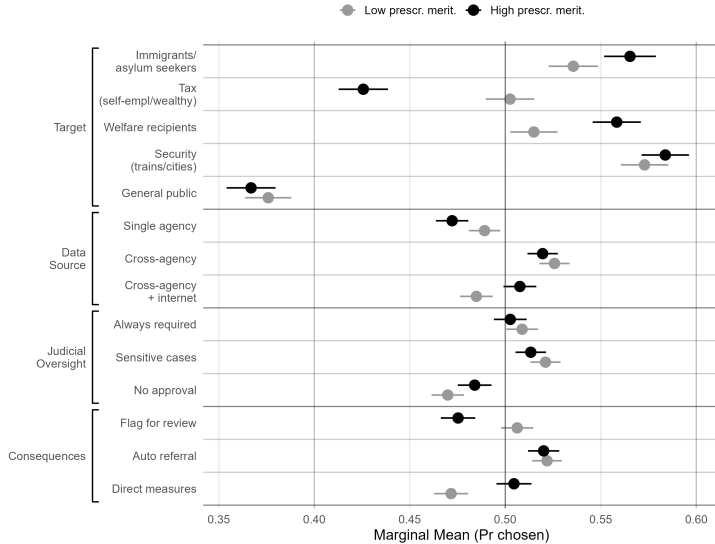
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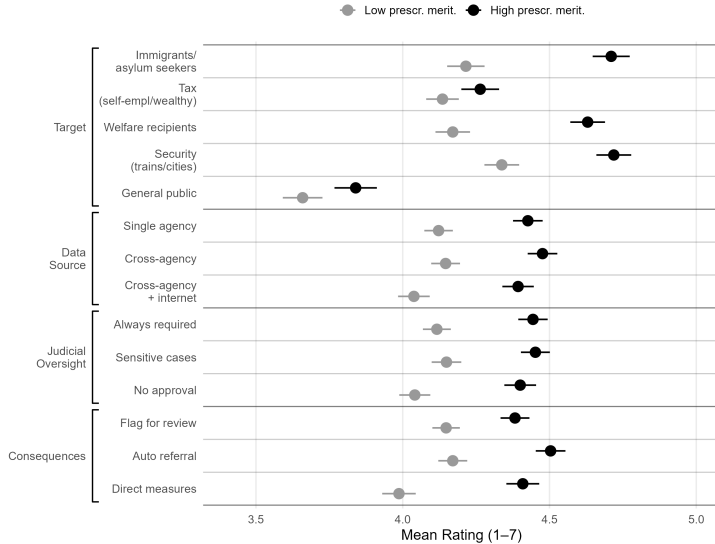


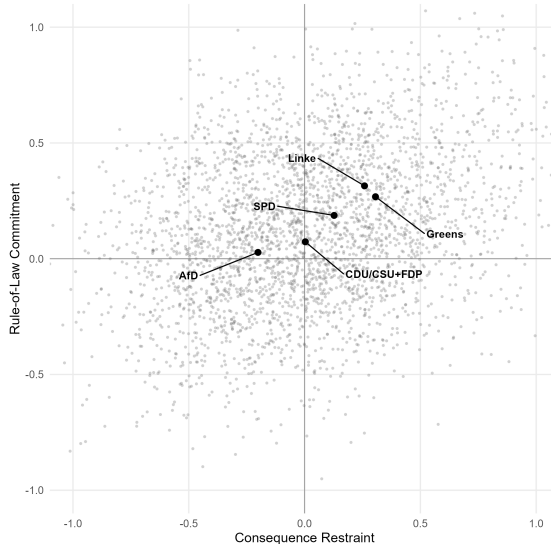
H5: Meritocracy amplifies deprivation





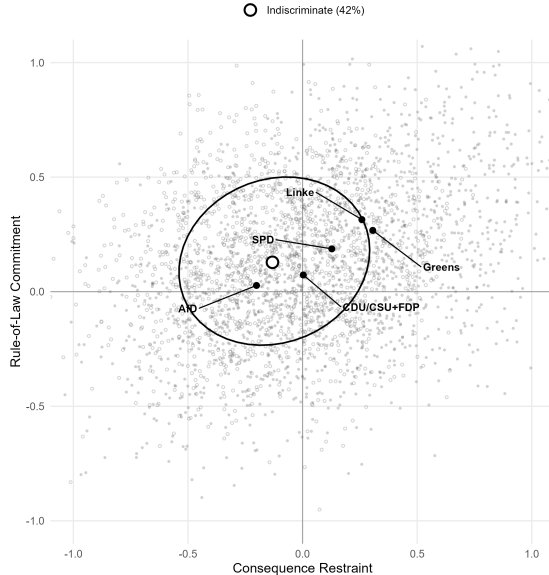
H5: Meritocracy alone, ratings



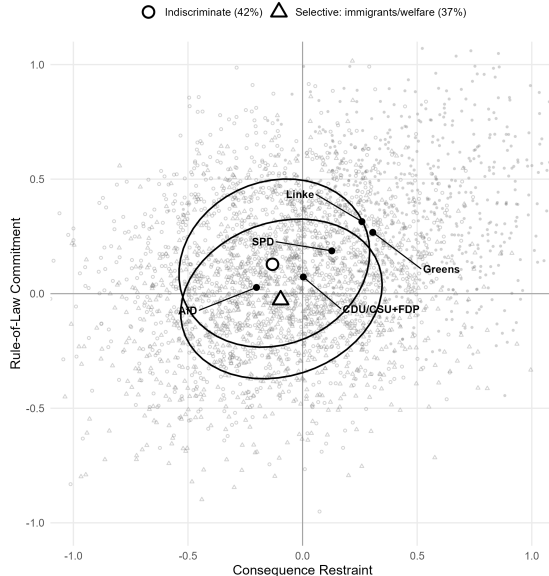


Each dot is one respondent: how much utility they lose from **direct measures** (x) and from **dropping judicial approval** (y)

Black points: mean position of each party electorate

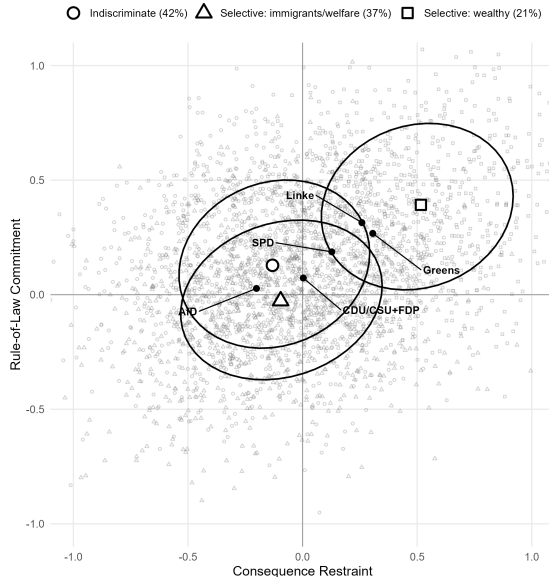


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Top-targeting (21%): only group whose utility for the wealthy exceeds immigrants/welfare; furthest left (3.9 vs. 5.6/5.9); 4% AfD; the **only** group that values the judge for **every** target

- Breyer, Zollinger & Palmtag (2026), same country, open-ended answers: naming **undeserving winners** does not separate AfD from Green voters and peaks among Linke voters; only **whom** they name differs. Same level-vs-target split
- Their **status and recognition** reading is covered: our relative deprivation items measure felt status loss (“less than I deserve”, “other groups are treated preferentially”) and behave like material hardship, raising the **level**, not selecting the target
- **Conspiratorial thinking** and **low institutional trust** behave like meritocratic beliefs: both go together with more support for immigrant surveillance and less for the wealthy
- Citizens who think in conspiracies, over-identify with meritocratic norms, and **distrust** the state yet want it rebuilt in a more authoritarian form: Amlinger & Nachtwey’s *libertarian authoritarianism*
- The privacy-security tradeoff is **group-contingent**, i.e., heterogeneous preferences for institutional safeguards dependent on target

Amlinger & Nachtwey (2025); Davis & Silver (2004); Simonovits, McCoy & Littvay (2022); Breyer, Zollinger & Palmtag (2026)

- Citizens support authoritarian surveillance when it promises to enforce a rule that institutions currently do not enforce – a perceived **institutional gap**
- Respondents differentiate strongly between targets and relax procedural safeguards for groups they judge undeserving
- **Prescriptive meritocratic beliefs**, not deprivation or zero-sum thinking, predict this selectivity
- the **authoritarian animosity here is horizontal**, running within classes along the logic of deservingness rather than along party lines or vertically between classes

Thank you!

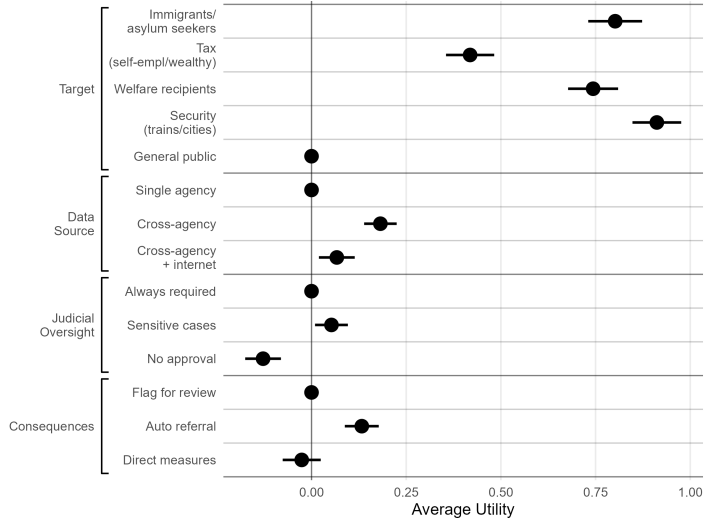
david.karpa@tum.de · michael.rochlitz@area.ox.ac.uk

Appendix

H1: structural utilities main

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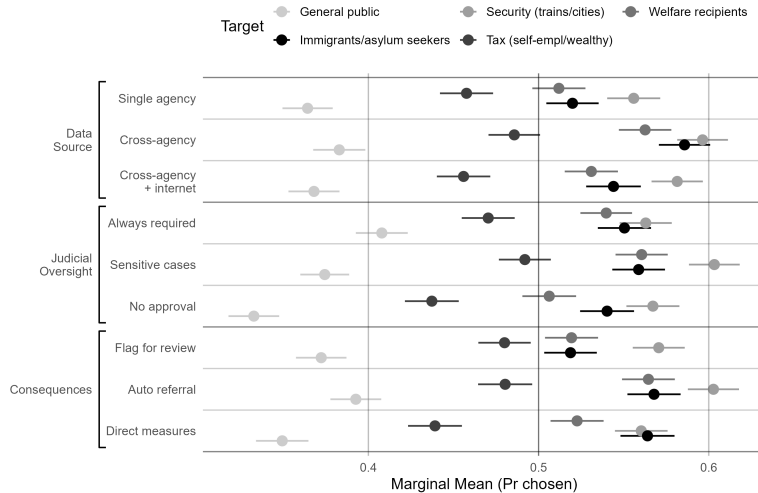
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H2: safeguard marginal means by target main

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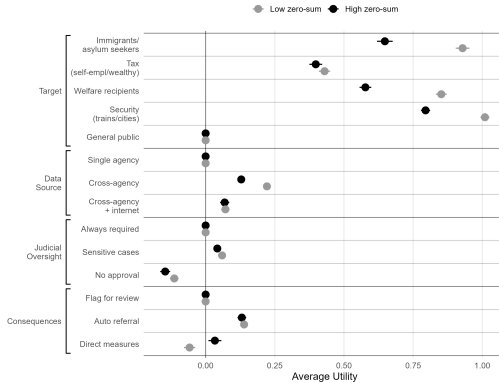


H3/H4: structural utilities main

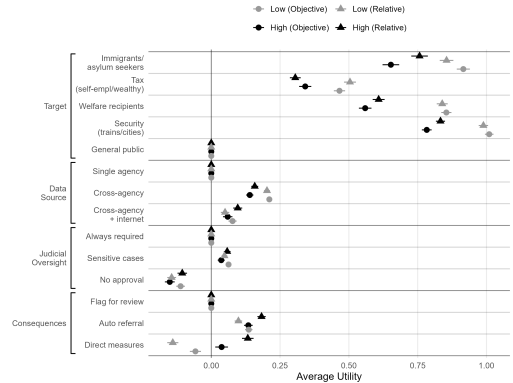
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Zero-sum (utilities)



Deprivation (utilities)

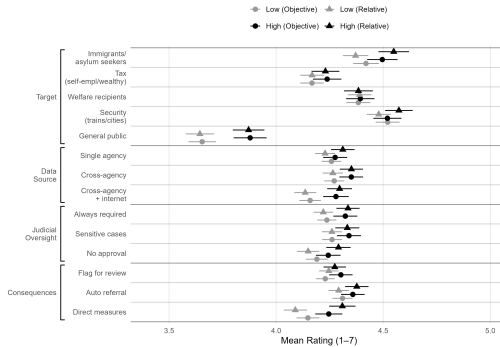


H4: rating replication & H3/H4 self-interest check main

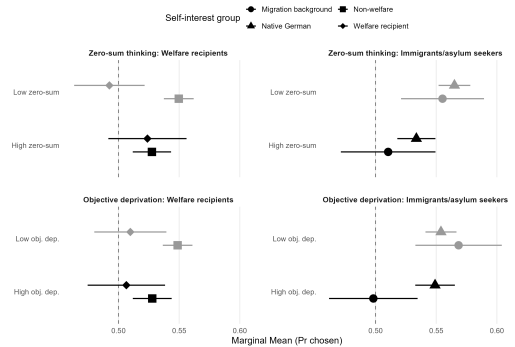
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Rating replication (deprivation)



Self-interest (welfare status, migration background)



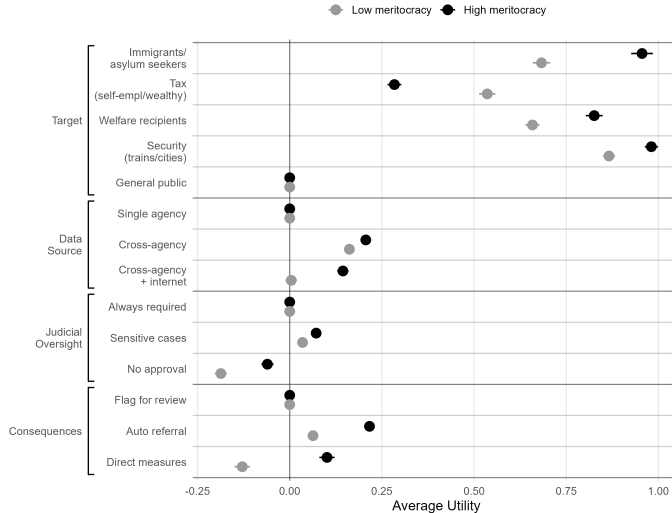
- Egoistic, nostalgic, fraternal relative deprivation, and objective material hardship each reproduce the H4 pattern: a positive main effect on ratings with null or negative target interactions
- Includes the item closest to offended meritocratic entitlement (“I receive less than I deserve”), which behaves like the other egoistic items
- Prescriptive meritocracy shows the reverse profile throughout

Not an artifact of pooling heterogeneous items.

H5: structural utilities by prescriptive meritocracy main

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- Prescriptive meritocracy: near-zero main effect on ratings ($b = -0.021$, n.s.), largest target interactions in the study (Immigrants $\times$ Merit: $b = +0.250$, $p < .001$; Welfare $\times$ Merit: $b = +0.205$, $p < .001$)
- Deprivation and zero-sum thinking: significant main effect (rel. dep. $b = +0.085$, $p < .01$; ZST $b = +0.124$, $p < .001$), null or negative target interactions (Welfare $\times$ Dep: $b = -0.115$, $p < .001$; Immigrants $\times$ ZST: $b = -0.102$, $p < .01$)

Level and direction are carried by different measures.

Group	%	Security	Welfare	Wealthy	Immigrants	Judicial appr.
Indiscriminate	42	0.66	0.39	0.31	0.47	0.13
Bottom-targeting	37	1.11	1.04	0.21	1.29	-0.03
Top-targeting	21	1.08	0.88	0.98	0.65	0.39

Group	Zero-sum	Rel. dep.	Meritocracy	L-R (1-10)	AfD %
Indiscriminate	2.77	2.79	2.77	5.6	26
Bottom-targeting	2.40	2.54	3.05	5.9	34
Top-targeting	2.53	2.25	2.59	3.9	4

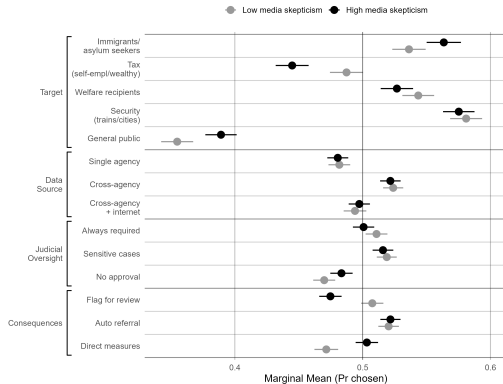
Party electorate	<i>n</i>	Cons. restraint	Judicial appr.
AfD	767	-0.20	0.03
CDU/CSU + FDP	638	0.00	0.07
SPD	369	0.13	0.19
Greens	293	0.31	0.27
Die Linke	292	0.26	0.32

$k = 3$ chosen by silhouette width (0.20 at $k = 3$ vs. 0.15 at $k = 4$); identical partition under two random seeds.

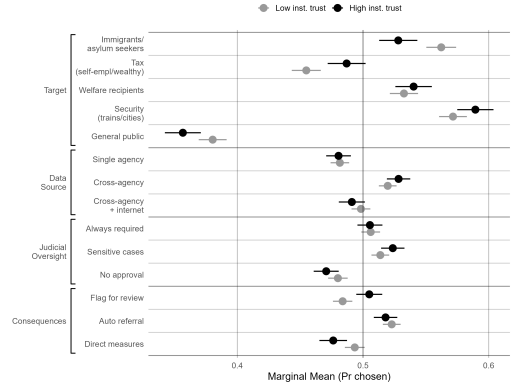
Group	Gen. public	Security	Welfare	Wealthy	Immigrants
Indiscriminate	-0.20	0.01	-0.11	-0.09	-0.02
Bottom-targeting	-0.44	0.19	0.01	-0.03	0.10
Top-targeting	-0.56	-0.10	-0.34	-0.23	-0.28

- Negative = the group values the judge for that target. Top-targeting is the only group that values the judge for **every** target
- The other two turn positive for security (indiscriminate) or for security and immigrants (bottom-targeting), meaning these respondents prefer dropping the judge there

Conspiratorial thinking



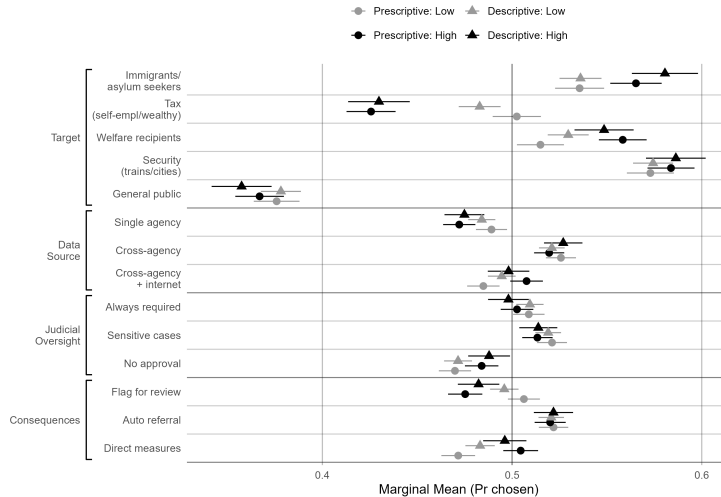
Institutional trust



Prescriptive vs. descriptive meritocracy

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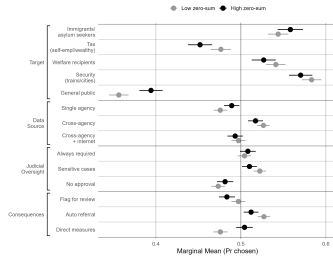


Zero-sum thinking: robustness across operationalizations

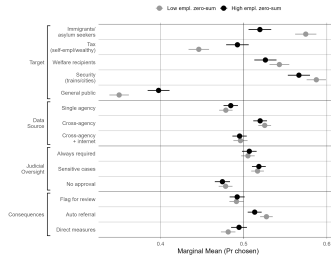
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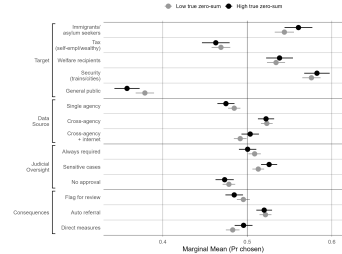
"Immigrants take jobs"



Employer-worker item



True zero-sum items



- Of 3,165 respondents: 448 East, 2,572 West, 145 Berlin (reported separately)
- Prescriptive meritocratic beliefs indistinguishable across regions (3.20 East vs. 3.24 West, effort sub-index); equivalence test rules out any difference > 0.2 SD ($p = .002$); unchanged for pre-reunification birth cohorts
- Institutional trust and relative deprivation **do** differ by region
- Rating-based target $\times$ East interaction significant ($F(4, 60,384) = 3.57$, $p = .006$: eastern respondents differentiate slightly less); forced-choice measure, the primary estimand, shows no regional difference
- Two limitations: current residence is a noisy indicator of GDR socialization, and the GDR was a surveillance state as well as a planned economy

- 86 respondents completed the survey in less than one third of the median response time (15.5 minutes); kept in the analysis sample per pre-registration
- Every H1–H5 estimate repeated with and without them: largest absolute shift is 0.0056, no estimate changes sign
- One estimate crosses the 5% threshold (objective deprivation $\times$ tax interaction: $p = .043$ full sample, $p = .058$ without flagged respondents), point estimate moves by 0.0014

Descriptive statistics: scales & correlations

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Variable	Items	Mean	SD	Min	Median	Max	Scale	α
Prescriptive meritocracy (full)	4	2.84	0.51	1.00	2.75	4.00	1-4	0.537
Effort sub-index	2	3.23	0.66	1.00	3.00	4.00	1-4	0.662
Capacity sub-index	2	2.45	0.65	1.00	2.50	4.00	1-4	0.412
Descriptive meritocracy	4	2.60	0.56	1.00	2.75	4.00	1-4	0.651
Objective deprivation	4	1.97	0.66	1.00	2.00	4.00	1-4	0.702
Relative deprivation	5	2.58	0.71	1.00	2.60	4.00	1-4	0.839
Zero-sum thinking (BZSG)	8	2.58	0.55	1.00	2.62	4.00	1-4	0.837
Immigrants take jobs (false ZS)	1	2.34	0.92	1.00	2.00	4.00	1-4	—
Fiscal equalization (true ZS)	1	2.77	0.72	1.00	3.00	4.00	1-4	—
Entrepreneurs/workers (false ZS)	1	2.48	0.83	1.00	2.00	4.00	1-4	—
Landlord/tenant (true ZS)	1	3.35	0.66	1.00	3.00	4.00	1-4	—
True zero-sum index	2	3.06	0.53	1.00	3.00	4.00	1-4	0.282
Institutional trust	4	2.38	0.67	1.00	2.50	4.00	1-4	0.825
Media skepticism	1	4.31	1.95	1.00	4.00	7.00	1-7	—
Left-right self-placement	1	5.31	1.86	1.00	5.00	10.00	1-10	—
Age (years)	1	47.84	15.36	18.00	49.00	74.00	18-74	—
Life satisfaction	1	6.13	2.34	0.00	7.00	10.00	0-10	—
Subjective income in childhood	1	3.14	0.88	1.00	3.00	5.00	1-5	—
Subjective income today	1	3.15	0.94	1.00	3.00	5.00	1-5	—
Frequency of social contact	1	2.73	1.09	1.00	2.00	5.00	1-5	—
Group memberships (count)	1	0.70	0.99	0.00	0.00	8.00	0-9	—

Note: $N = 3,165$ for every variable; none of the items has a missing value. Indices are item means, and α is Cronbach's raw alpha, which is undefined for single-item measures. Four-point items run from 1 (strongly disagree) to 4 (strongly agree). The two subjective income items and the contact frequency item are coded so that 1 is the most favourable category (far above average, daily contact) and higher values are less favourable. The capacity sub-index reaches $\alpha = 0.412$ with an inter-item correlation of $r = 0.26$, well below the effort sub-index ($\alpha = 0.662$, $r = 0.50$). It enters the analysis only as a robustness check and is never used to support a substantive claim on its own. Dropping the 86 respondents who failed both attention checks or answered faster than one third of the median duration moves no mean by more than 0.014 scale points and no alpha by more than 0.011.

Correlations between core constructs

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	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)	(14)
(1) Prescriptive meritocracy	1													
(2) Effort sub-index	.79***	1												
(3) Capacity sub-index	.78***	.22***	1											
(4) Descriptive meritocracy	.23***	.23***	.13***	1										
(5) Zero-sum thinking (BZSG)	.04*	-.07***	.13***	-.43***	1									
(6) ZS: immigrants take jobs	.10***	-.03	.19***	-.08***	.27***	1								
(7) ZS: fiscal equalization	.15***	.09***	.14***	-.05**	.23***	.18***	1							
(8) ZS: entrepreneurs/workers	-.08***	-.14***	.02	-.36***	.55***	.23***	.16***	1						
(9) ZS: landlord/tenant	.13***	.22***	-.01	-.12***	.20***	.05**	.16***	.14***	1					
(10) Objective deprivation	-.07***	-.12***	.01	-.24***	.24***	.18***	.04*	.21***	-.01	1				
(11) Relative deprivation	.03	-.01	.06**	-.32***	.40***	.30***	.12***	.31***	.15***	.54***	1			
(12) Institutional trust	.08***	.08***	.05**	.23***	-.20***	-.24***	-.05**	-.16***	-.06***	-.23***	-.41***	1		
(13) Media skepticism	.09***	.02	.12***	-.13***	.26***	.34***	.10***	.17***	.02	.33***	.46***	-.55***	1	
(14) Left-right self-placement	.21***	.12***	.21***	.10***	.01	.25***	.11***	-.08***	-.07***	.07***	.15***	-.20***	.32***	1

Note: Pearson correlations, $N = 3,165$.
Leading zeros are omitted. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$. Rows (2) and (3) are the two sub-indices of row (1), so their correlation with it follows from the construction of the index.

Dimension	Category	Sample unweighted	Sample weighted	Population
Gender	Male	49.9	50.1	50.1
	Female	50.1	49.9	49.9
Age group	18–29	16.9	17.9	17.9
	30–39	17.8	18.2	18.2
	40–49	16.1	16.8	16.8
	50–59	21.8	21.2	21.2
	60–74	27.5	25.9	25.9
Education (ISCED)	Low	9.7	15.9	15.9
	Medium	50.5	49.9	49.9
	High	39.8	34.2	34.2
Region	West	85.8	85.0	85.0
	East	14.2	15.0	15.0
Federal state	Baden-Württemberg	13.6	13.2	13.4
	Bavaria	16.1	16.0	15.9
	Berlin	4.6	4.5	4.4
	Brandenburg	3.2	3.4	3.0
	Bremen	0.9	0.9	0.8
	Hamburg	2.2	2.2	2.2
	Hesse	7.0	7.0	7.5
	Mecklenburg-West Pomerania	2.0	2.1	1.9
	Lower Saxony	9.6	9.4	9.6
	North Rhine-Westphalia	21.4	21.0	21.7
	Rhineland-Palatinate	5.1	5.2	5.0
	Saarland	1.3	1.3	1.2
	Saxony	4.6	4.9	4.7
	Saxony-Anhalt	2.1	2.2	2.6
	Schleswig-Holstein	4.1	4.3	3.5
	Thuringia	2.3	2.4	2.5

Note: All entries are percentages. $N = 3,158$; the 7 respondents who chose a third gender category are dropped from the weighting because no population benchmark exists for them. Weights come from iterative proportional fitting on gender, age group, education and East/West region, trimmed at four times the median and renormalised. The design effect is 1.055 and the effective sample size is 2,994. Benchmarks: gender and age from Eurostat demo.pjanagroup (1 January 2023, ages 18–74, the 18 and 19 year olds interpolated as two fifths of the 15–19 group); education from Eurostat edat.life_03 (2024, ISCED 2011, ages 25–64); the East/West split from the Federal Statistical Office population update (31 December 2023); federal states from Eurostat demo.r.pjangrp3 (1 January 2023, NUTS-1, ages 18–74, same interpolation). Federal state was a quota but not a raking margin, so the weighted column is not calibrated to it.

- OLS regressions of the three moderators on deprivation and sociodemographic controls explain little variance in any of the three
- Knowing how deprived a respondent is tells us little about how strongly that respondent holds meritocratic or zero-sum beliefs
- East Germany indicator statistically indistinguishable from zero in all three models

	Effort beliefs (2 items)	Capacity beliefs (2 items)	Zero-sum thinking (8 items)
Intercept	3.152*** (0.080)	2.183*** (0.076)	1.944*** (0.064)
Relative deprivation	0.068** (0.022)	0.063** (0.022)	0.286*** (0.017)
Objective deprivation	-0.144*** (0.024)	0.000 (0.024)	0.031 (0.018)
Female	-0.014 (0.024)	-0.129*** (0.023)	-0.133*** (0.018)
Age 30–39	0.080* (0.041)	0.031 (0.040)	-0.029 (0.030)
Age 40–49	0.144*** (0.042)	0.064 (0.041)	-0.100** (0.032)
Age 50–59	0.124** (0.039)	0.106** (0.039)	-0.089** (0.030)
Age 60–74	0.136*** (0.037)	0.154*** (0.037)	-0.117*** (0.028)
Education: Medium	0.098* (0.046)	0.094* (0.042)	0.002 (0.034)
Education: High	0.121* (0.046)	0.096* (0.042)	-0.070 (0.034)

Notes: Estimated on the full analysis sample of all completed interviews; the pre-registered sensitivity analysis excluding flagged respondents is reported separately. All dependent variables and both deprivation predictors are item means on the original four-point scales and are not standardized, so coefficients are scale points and are not comparable to the z-standardized coefficients in Table ??.

OLS with HC2 robust standard errors in parentheses. Reference categories: Age 18–29, Education: Low, West Germany. *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$.

- Structural deep-learning estimator (Acharya, Hainmueller & Xu 2026): a neural network embedded in a random-utility logit, preference parameters vary with 14 respondent moderators
- $K = 5$ basis functions, 300 training epochs, fixed seed; double debiased ML inference, cross-fitted, clustered at the respondent level
- Population-averaged utilities correlate with a homogeneous logit at $r = 1.00$, largest absolute deviation 0.05 on the logit scale
- Judicial penalties: from a second fit with target $\times$ oversight as one interacted attribute (15 levels)
- Three preference groups: k -means ($k = 3$) on the ten-dimensional respondent-level utility vectors, labeled by the group's highest mean target utility